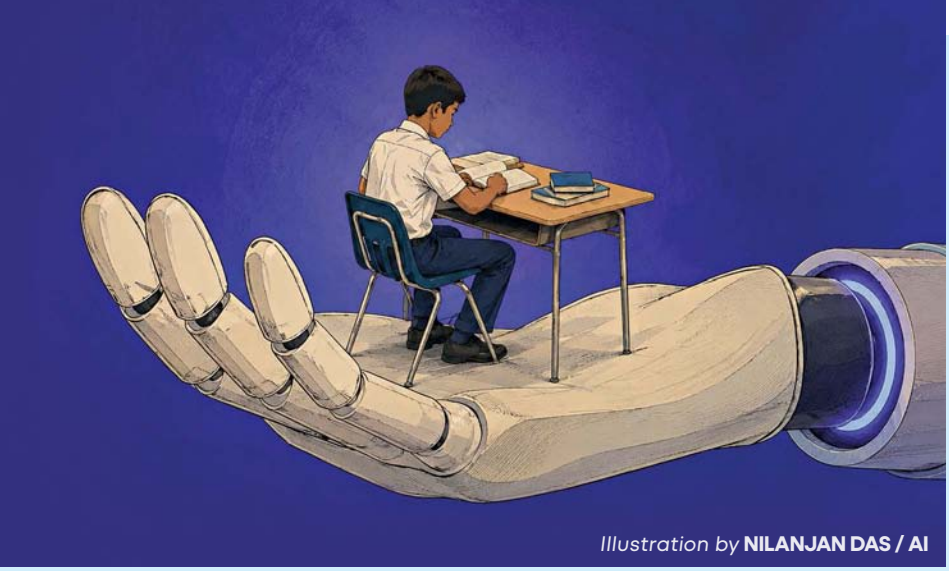


Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS / AI**

Takeaways

- **An AI-based tool studies data to mark vulnerability**
- **A special team follows up with counselling, schemes**

flagged 167,000 students across Gujarat as being at risk; 55 per cent (92,243) were girls. For 2026–27, it has identified another 118,000 vulnerables.

SYSTEMIC BLOOD LOSS

Gujarat reports zero dropouts at the primary level, better than the national average of 0.3 per cent, but the picture begins to slip around Class 6-8, with a 4.8 per cent dropout, roughly 148,000 children, against an all-India average of 3.6 per cent. Then comes the cliff. In Classes 9-10, dropouts leap to 15.7 per cent, well above the national 9.5 per cent. The headcount doubles to about 275,000 students. Cumulatively, only 54.5 per cent of children who join Class 1 in Gujarat are still in school by Class 12.

Activists read in this the familiar devil: economic precarity. Mittal Solanki, 13, a Grade 8 student from Haradri village in Anand district, typified this. Absent through June 2025, the EWS flagged her, and in July, her class teacher, principal and local education officers won over her mother. "Her father died early, so the family leaned on her for housework while the others earned. We told her mother about Namo Lakshmi, which pays a girl student Rs 10,000 a year for education," says Varshaben Parmar, her teacher, who is glad Mittal now attends Grade 9 regularly.

Every June, Gujarat organises an enrolment campaign that sees legislators, bureaucrats and teachers fan out to stanch the dropout rates at source. This year, minister of state for education Rivaba Jadeja trekked through the hilly villages of north Gujarat to the homes of dropouts. An activist working with the government believes the efforts are sincere, but says AI alone will not suffice. "The deeper rot is absence of teachers and quality education. It can be done, but political will is needed," he adds. ■

ANI





MAKING COMMON CAUSE Suspended Congress leader Madan Lal Jalalpur (left) and former Punjab CM Charanjit Singh Channi

Takeaways

- **Ex-MLA earns suspension for saying Warring can't lead Congress to victory in 2027**
- **Anti-Warring sentiment unites camps; central team faces pro-Channi slogans**

isters Bharat Bhushan Ashu, Pargat Singh and Gurpreet Singh Kangar, several MLAs and others. By night, the suspended leader had become a rallying point for the dissidents

INSUBORDINATION?

Jalalpur's crime? He had questioned Warring's ability to lead the party to victory in next year's assembly election, and issued harsh critiques on general secretary K.C. Venugopal as well as Baghel for ignoring local sentiment and not seeing the writing on the wall. For Warring, that itself became a question of leadership—what weight would his word carry if such indiscipline carried no consequences? So he finally chose to shed the diplomatic route and go hard.

That has ended up creating a pretext for open war. The Channi camp paints Jalalpur as the first casualty of an attempt to squeeze out leaders unwilling to fall in line behind Warring. His suspension has given the critics something they lacked until now: a common cause. For months, unease within the Punjab Congress had been visible but scattered. Several seniors complained privately about concentration of authority. Others worried about who would control candidate selection in 2027.

Channi, meanwhile, is seeking to build up street cred as a leader in his own right. A surprise last-minute choice by Rahul Gandhi as a replacement for Amarinder Singh in September 2021, his six-month tenure as Punjab's first Dalit CM ended in bruising defeat. As the power roulette spins, he fancies his chances for another go. Anti-Warring sentiment has given his flight some lift, as grievances coalesce. Warring's attempt to be a stern taskmaster may have ironically strengthened the very challenge he wanted to contain. The toughest job perhaps belongs to the referee, a hapless Baghel. ■